INDIAN FREEDOM STRUGGLE

A Chronological Journey: 1857 – 1950

1857 – 1900: The Awakening

1857

The First War of Independence (Sepoy Mutiny)

The first major organized resistance against British East India Company rule. It started in Meerut and spread across Northern and Central India, becoming a symbol of resistance.

1858

Government of India Act

The British Crown took direct control of India from the East India Company, marking the beginning of the British Raj.

1885

Formation of the Indian National Congress (INC)

Founded by Allan Octavian Hume, the INC provided a platform for educated Indians to seek political representation and civil rights.

1905 – 1918: Radicalism and the Return of Gandhi

1905

Partition of Bengal & Swadeshi Movement

Lord Curzon's decision to partition Bengal on communal lines sparked massive protests and the Swadeshi movement, which promoted Indian-made goods.

1906

Formation of the All India Muslim League

Established in Dhaka to safeguard the rights of Muslims in India and voice their political aspirations.

1915

Return of Mahatma Gandhi

Mahatma Gandhi returned from South Africa, bringing his philosophy of Satyagraha (truth-force) and non-violent resistance to the forefront.

1916

Lucknow Pact

A historic agreement between the Indian National Congress and the Muslim League to work together for constitutional reforms.

1919 – 1939: The Era of Mass Movements

1919

Jallianwala Bagh Massacre & Rowlatt Act

British troops fired on a peaceful gathering in Amritsar. This atrocity followed the repressive Rowlatt Act and became a turning point in the struggle.

1920

Non-Cooperation Movement

Launched by Gandhi to demand Purna Swaraj (self-rule). Millions boycotted British institutions, titles, and goods.

1922

Chauri Chaura Incident

Following violence in Chauri Chaura, Gandhi suspended the Non-Cooperation Movement, emphasizing that non-violence was paramount.

1928

Simon Commission Protests

Massive protests with the slogan "Simon Go Back" took place against the all-British commission sent to propose reforms.

1930

Salt Satyagraha (Dandi March)

Gandhi's 240-mile march to produce salt in defiance of the British salt tax, sparking the Civil Disobedience Movement.

1935

Government of India Act

Introduced provincial autonomy and provided for a federation of India, though it was largely criticized by Indian leaders.

1940 – 1947: The Final Push

1940

Lahore Resolution

The Muslim League formally raised the demand for a separate nation, Pakistan.

1942

Quit India Movement

Gandhi's call to the British to "Quit India" and to Indians to "Do or Die." This led to the arrest of almost the entire INC leadership.

1943

Indian National Army (Azad Hind Fauj)

Subhash Chandra Bose led the INA to liberate India from British rule with help from the Axis powers during WWII.

1947 (Aug 15)

Independence and Partition

India achieved independence but was partitioned into India and Pakistan, accompanied by mass displacement and violence.

1948 – 1950: Building the Republic

1948

Integration of Princely States

Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel spearheaded the integration of over 560 princely states into the Indian Union.

1949 (Nov 26)

Adoption of the Constitution

The Constituent Assembly of India adopted the Constitution, the result of nearly three years of deliberation.

1950 (Jan 26)

India Becomes a Republic

The Constitution came into force, establishing India as a Sovereign Democratic Republic. Dr. Rajendra Prasad was sworn in as the first President.